

ZANZIBAR TANZANIA

Swahili Curry on Zanzibar

For over 1,000 years, Zanzibar has been a cultural melting pot. Its historic center, Stone Town, has a captivating blend of African, Arabic, Asian, and European architecture, and there's a rich mix of languages and cultures among its inhabitants. Zanzibari dishes are equally cosmopolitan, such as *mnazi*, a tangy, coconut-milk curry that seamlessly blends Indian, Arabic, and homegrown elements.



The very name “Zanzibar” drips with exoticism; most visitors agree that the Spice Island, which lies in the Indian Ocean off Tanzania’s Swahili coast, is one

of those travel destinations that truly matches expectations. Around the coast, mysterious ruins recall a millennium of maritime trade with Arabia. The pristine swaths of palm-lined white sand give way to a sea that offers magical diving and snorkeling, and the opportunity to swim with dolphins.

Zanzibar’s cultural heart is historic Stone Town: a labyrinthine knot of narrow alleys, ostentatious Omani palaces, and multistory Swahili homesteads emanating from a medieval harbor with an imposing 17th-century Omani fort. The town’s prosperity peaked in the mid-19th century, when it served as a capital for the Sultan of Oman and formed the main trade conduit for slaves captured on the African mainland. One of the most symbolically resonant landmarks on the island is the Anglican Cathedral, built on the site of the town’s notorious slave market.

Today, the giddy smell of spiced Swahili *kahawa* (coffee) permeates Stone Town, punctuated by tantalizing wafts of home cooking. There are stands piled with aromatic foodstuffs; fresh and dried spices vie with the heady scents of juicy fresh fruits.

Zanzibari cuisine has been influenced by centuries of trade with Arabia and Asia, and its most popular dish is Swahili coconut curry. Made with chicken, fish, or seafood – and sometimes even beef – it incorporates the golden-brown Zanzibari masala, a superb mix of ground cinnamon, roasted coriander, cumin and fennel seeds, chili pepper, and cilantro. This imparts a spicy tang that blends with fresh coconut milk to produce a curry with a deep, creamy texture and rich aftertaste. Accompanied by *wali na nazi* (rice boiled in coconut milk), chapatis, and spinach-like *sukuma wiki*, Swahili curry – *mnazi* – is the culinary embodiment of the glorious Spice Island and its cosmopolitan past. It’s arguably best eaten from the overflowing dinner stands of the waterfront Forodhani Gardens, which emerge mysteriously by the shore as the sun sets over the Indian Ocean, offering a unique sensory treat.

What Else to Eat

Seafood features strongly on Zanzibari menus, with a particular favorite being marinated and grilled **shrimp**. These are served at a cluster of food stands on Forodhani Gardens, alongside other East African favorites such as **nyama choma** (grilled meat), **chapatis** (flatbreads), and **sugar cane juice**. Fresh fruit is also prominent, including oversized and super-tasty coconuts and pineapples, but the adventurous might want to try **embe ker**i (unripe mango sprinkled with chili pepper flakes) or the delicious but foul-smelling, spiky-coated durian fruit. Other popular Swahili dishes on the island include **boko-boko**, an aromatic porridge-type dish made of shredded meat and bulgur wheat, and **urojo** (literally “mixed”) soup, in which cubes of grilled beef are placed with potatoes, chickpea fritters, and whatever else is available in a fruity stock.



Above Zanzibar’s uncrowded beaches are interspersed by small fishing villages



The Best Places to Eat Swahili Curry

Monsoon Restaurant moderate

The ultimate Zanzibari night out is provided by this well-established traditional restaurant, especially if you time your visit to coincide with the live *taarab* (classical Swahili music) performances on Wednesday and Friday nights. The terrace is ideal for an early evening drink, allowing you to watch the sun set over Forodhani Gardens while sailing dhows billow romantically across the Indian Ocean. Inside, the restaurant is divided into two areas. The homey bar is the place to relax over a fresh cocktail or ginger-spiced coffee, accompanied perhaps by a sweet *kashata* (nutty cookie). The main culinary action takes place next door, in a large open area decorated in the Swahili way, with *mikeka* matting spread across the floor and ground-level seating on brightly colored cushions set around knee-high tables, their tops adorned with fragrant fresh jasmine. An imaginative à la carte menu combines traditional Zanzibari favorites – Swahili chicken curry, kingfish in coconut sauce, shrimp marinated in garlic, ginger, and lime – with fusion fare that incorporates influences from all corners of the Mediterranean. There’s a four-course dinner for diners with adventurous palates.

Hurumzi St., Stone Town, Zanzibar; open 10 AM–midnight daily; www.monsoon-zanzibar.com

Also on Zanzibar

Situated on the ground floor of the historic “House of Tea” hotel on Kelele Square, **Beyt al Chai Restaurant** (www.bluebayzanzibar.com; **expensive**) might not look like anything special in daylight, but the food is arguably the finest on Zanzibar, and it’s complemented by a lovely candlelit ambience at dinner. The cuisine can be categorized broadly as Swahili fusion, with keynote dishes including a Zanzibar casserole of seafood poached in coconut and lemongrass broth, and there is an excellent wine list.

Also in Africa

Traditional Swahili cuisine is poorly represented at restaurants in Dar es Salaam, the largest city in Tanzania and former capital, but **Sweet Eazy Restaurant & Lounge** (www.sweeteazy.com; **moderate–expensive**) is a notable exception, serving an imaginative menu of traditional and fusion dishes including a superb seafood coconut curry. The arched decor evokes traditional Swahili architecture and there’s live music on weekends. On Shela Beach, on the outskirts of the time-warped Kenyan port of Lamu, the stylish “barefoot luxury” **Peponi Hotel** (www.peponi-lamu.com; **expensive**) is renowned for its fresh seafood, whether you like it sushi-style, grilled plain, or curried in the traditional Swahili manner.